

module's hideout) after the blasts."

By now, Nisar is restless. "What will they do with me?" he asks, meaning the police. I remind him: "Do you realise how dangerous you have become?" His eyes flood with tears and he looks up at the ceiling. "Have you thought about your parents, what would they be going through?" He cries silently. He is perhaps the only one who is feeling the shock and realisation of what he has done. Maybe Nisar is not as hardened a jihadi as he would like to project.

■ Mohammed Shakeel, 26

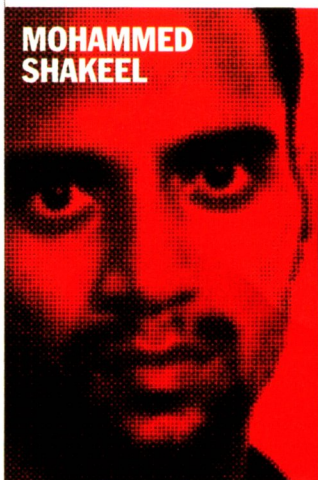
A final year student of economics at Jamia Millia Islamia, accused of planting bombs in Ahmedabad and Delhi's Karol Bagh.

With his face covered, Shakeel is waiting to be paraded in front of the cameras at a press conference by the south Delhi police. A member of his family is with him, so are a few friends who

I committed my life to Allah. Now nothing scares me, life and death are same," says Shakeel. He has no qualms in acknowledging that he planted a bomb in Ahmedabad. "I planted the parcel in Mani Nagar," he says. A regular at Atif's hideout, Shakeel lists the people who went with him to Ahmedabad: Nisar's cousin Shatab, Sajid and Khalid, all on the run, Zia-ur Rehman and Atif. They were frequent visitors at Atif's house. "This association was the most passionate phase for our life, nothing mattered, there was no ego, we can do anything for Allah."

Shakeel is believed to be second-in-command after Atif, so it comes as no surprise that he accompanied Atif to Ghaffar Market to plant the bombs. "We're all equals in the jihad for Allah, but I was associated longer with the Allah *ke bande* (men of God). He was happy with the way things were happening. A handful of Allah *ke bande* were able to paralyse the economic life of such a big country by targeting metros and noth-

MOHAMMED SHAKEEL



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risked meeting him. His face is covered. "Tell me about yourself," I ask. "I've already done that many times to the cops," he says, dismissing the question. Correcting his tone, he says, almost apologetically, "Sir, ask what you want to know, I am an open book, by Allah's grace."

He goes on to tell me that he has love for life, and wants to enjoy it to fullest. But, it should be a respectable life. "If you follow things that are happening in the world, also in India, Muslims are not welcome." There are two options, live a life full of contempt, get insulted and abused, or protest in the name of Allah. "I decided to do the latter because had it been only for me it would have not mattered, it's the name of Allah that they want to soil, and that is not acceptable."

Atif was the man behind his indoctrination as well. "I experienced in me an awakening after

ing much could be done about it. We gave back what we were getting from them," Shakeel says.

But like Nisar, he is also puzzled at being caught so easily. "Atif used to say no one can touch us, we are for Allah," he recollects. "He is dead, we are here, no regrets, it's Allah's test of our fortitude." The police have proof. "They have seized a bucket in which we kept *barood* (explosive) and plastic tape, timer watches and the bags we used," he says anxiously. He expresses no regret for having killed innocent people. He is clearly no leader, merely a follower, a novice who is yet to come to terms with the true meaning of jihad but dangerous nonetheless. He is one of those who have no qualms about being a terrorist. "As I told you there is nothing to hide. We are not thieves," he says. That makes him even more dangerous. ■